

TSANGAI BUSINESS GROWTH SERIES · #11

The Automation Playbook

Five plug-and-play automations that run your busywork while you sleep
— each one buildable in under an hour, no coding required.

WHO IT'S FOR

Owners who use AI daily but still
move everything between apps by
hand

TIME REQUIRED

15 min to plan · 1 hour to build

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

Your first automation picked,
mapped, and live this week

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

AI answers questions. Automation does the work.

Prompting is level one. Level two is connecting your apps so leads, invoices, and follow-ups move themselves. This playbook gives you five proven recipes and the exact steps to ship the first one.

Here's the shift that changes everything: stop thinking "what can AI write for me?" and start thinking "what happens automatically when a lead comes in?" The owners saving 10+ hours a week aren't better at prompting — they've simply wired the handoffs. One recipe at a time.

— Ray, TsangAI Consulting

WHY THIS MATTERS

24/7

Automations don't sleep, forget, or go on holiday — your follow-up runs at 2am

<1 hr

Each recipe in this playbook is buildable in under an hour with no code

5 recipes

Cover the leaks that cost service businesses the most: leads, invoices, reviews

THE ONE IDEA

Automate the handoffs, not the craft.

Your skill stays human. What gets automated is the boring bridge between apps: form → CRM, job done → invoice, invoice paid → review request. Every automation is just a trigger ("when this happens") plus an action ("do that").

Example: A pressure-washing company wired one recipe: website form → instant text reply → lead added to CRM → owner notified. Built on a Saturday morning. They went from "we'll call you back tomorrow" to answering in 30 seconds — without touching a phone.

YOUR 10-MINUTE QUICK WIN

- ☐ Read the five recipes on page 4
- ☐ Circle the one that plugs your biggest leak (usually Recipe 1)
- ☐ Write its trigger and action in one sentence: "When ____, then ____"
- ☐ Book a 1-hour build slot this week — that's the whole commitment

Five steps to your first live automation

1 Pick ONE recipe

Not two. The five on page 4 are ranked — Recipe 1 (instant lead reply) pays off fastest for almost every service business.

Do this: Circle one recipe and write its "When ____, then ____" sentence.

2 Map it on paper first

List every step a human does today: where the info starts, where it goes, what gets sent. If you can't draw it, you can't build it.

Do this: Run the Automation Spec Prompt on page 4 — it turns your description into a build plan.

3 Pick your hub and connect your apps

Zapier is easiest, Make is cheaper, n8n is the most powerful. Sign up, then connect the two apps in your recipe (your form tool and your email/SMS, for example).

Do this: Create the account and authorize both apps. That's half the build already done.

4 Build the ugly version and test it

One trigger, one or two actions, plain wording. Send a test lead through it yourself before it ever touches a real customer.

Do this: Submit your own form. Confirm the reply arrives and the data lands where it should.

5 Turn it on, then check it weekly

Go live, then look at the run history every Friday for a month: what fired, what failed, what felt robotic. Tune the wording, then start recipe two.

Do this: Add "check automations" to your Friday routine — two minutes, coffee in hand.

COMMON MISTAKES

This is where most business owners get stuck.

They design a ten-step masterpiece and never finish it. They automate a process that was broken to begin with — now it fails faster. And they set it live and never look again, until a customer gets three duplicate emails.

PRO TIP

Add a "notify me" action to every automation for its first month — a ping to your phone each time it runs. You'll catch weirdness early, and there's no better feeling than watching your business answer a lead while you're at your kid's game.

The five recipes + your build prompt

The Recipe Book ranked by payoff for service businesses

#	WHEN THIS HAPPENS...	...DO THIS AUTOMATICALLY	SAVES
1	New lead submits your website form	Instant reply (email or text) + lead saved to CRM + you get notified	Jobs won
2	Quote sent, no reply in 3 days	Friendly follow-up email goes out; reminder if still quiet at day 7	2–4 hrs/wk
3	Job marked complete	Invoice sent + review request 2 days later, with your review link	1–2 hrs/wk
4	Invoice unpaid at 7 / 14 / 21 days	Escalating polite reminders — you never chase money by hand again	Cash flow
5	Meeting ends (notetaker summary ready)	Summary + action items filed and emailed to attendees	1–2 hrs/wk

The Automation Spec Prompt

You are an automation consultant for small service businesses. I want to build: when **[TRIGGER]**, then **[ACTIONS]**. My tools: forms = **[TOOL]**, email = **[TOOL]**, CRM = **[TOOL OR "NONE"]**. I'll build it in **[ZAPIER / MAKE / N8N]**. Give me: 1) the exact step-by-step build order, 2) the message text for each automated send (friendly, under 80 words), 3) what to test before going live, 4) the one failure case most likely to bite me.

Pre-Flight Checklist

- ☐ The manual process works and is written down
- ☐ Trigger and actions fit in one sentence
- ☐ Automated messages sound like us, not a robot
- ☐ I tested it on myself before any customer saw it
- ☐ There's a "notify me" so I see every run this month

KEEP THE HUMAN MOMENT

Automate the instant reply — but make the second touch personal. "System answers in seconds, human calls within the hour" is the combination customers rave about.

Turn this guide into one win this week.

A guide you read changes nothing. A page you fill in does. Two minutes — do it while it's fresh.

1 • WHERE I AM TODAY

My recipe — When _____, then _____

2 • THE ONE THING I'M FIXING THIS WEEK

My one fix: _____

The first small step (under 15 minutes): _____

Small beats big. Pick something you can finish in one sitting.

3 • WHEN I'M DOING IT

Day: _____ Time: _____ Booked in my calendar? ☐

Open your calendar and book it now — a plan without a time slot is a wish.

4 • AFTER — WHAT HAPPENED

My result (hours saved, jobs booked, thing shipped): _____

What I'll do differently next time: _____

NOTES

KEEP THE STREAK

One fix a week is 52 upgrades a year. When this page is full, re-take the guide — a rising score is proof your systems are working.